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Marty Grosz

Marty Grosz is a guitarist and singer who brings to life songs from a bygone era. His totally acoustic approach to music is a welcome change, and a unique brand of humor is an integral part of his numerous recordings. He was born in Germany in 1930 but moved to the U.S. at an early age. The dance bands of the 40s inspired Marty to a career in music and his early bandmates included Dick Wellstood and Art Hodes. He has performed with Soprano Summit and in tributes to the music of Bix Beiderbecke. Marty's own group performs frequently at festivals and jazz parties in the U.S. and he travels to Europe regularly.

Marty was interviewed by Monk Rowe in Los Angeles on September 4, 1995.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, attending the L.A. Classic Jazz Fest and it's our pleasure to have with us Marty Grosz, who is an acoustic guitarist and purveyor of a special form of jazz I think, that we're going to try to get a handle on here. Thanks for your time in joining us today. I have to, I want to start out and ask you, and you have to excuse my accent, okay, but what is this statement here, "Do you mean you vant to sit in vront of dose schving orchestras un do ching, ching, ching all night?"

MG: Yes, that was my mother, who was very happy. I had sort of learned secretly, because I don't know, you know when you really care about something, I really cared. I'm not one of those guys who had an instrument thrust in his hand although I did have a ukulele thrust in my hand when I was about eight years old. We had lessons at school but it didn't work, all of us sat around, twenty kids in one room, people banging on drums, pianos, all that stuff, trombones, and what are you going to do with a uke? Nothing. You know, that's the only instrument we had at home. I think my father, my mother actually wanted to have a piano, but we were in a rented house and I think my father, I don't know if this is true, but he might have thought that the piano was too much of a symbol of some kind of bourgeois respectability.

MR: And we wouldn't want that, right?

MG: No.

MR: No kidding?

MG: I'm assuming that. So I think that on the scale of things important to spend money on at a time when money was not that available, I think he probably would have thought you know, he remembered from his youth in Germany, every house had what they called the "gout de stoupa," the good room that was like the living room that was never used. You know what I mean? And the piano was often this sacred symbol with a piano scarf on it,

piano. You know, and so forth. And maybe that's what he thought, I don't know. So anyway, I sort of got a guitar, I saved up my money doing errands and allowance and jobs and things like that, and I went to New York and got like a twenty dollar guitar, a terrible thing, I didn't know any better, but I kept fiddling with it at home. And I was so embarrassed kind of that I was so lousy. You know I'd try to play along with records. Lionel Hampton I remember was one of the ones. "Rhythm, Rhythm" by Lionel Hampton, with Johnny Hodges and Allan Reuss was on it and Cozy Cole and Jess Stacey and everything. And I'd last about half a chorus before the muscles would give out. And so anyway, so one night, a friend of ours came over and he brought a little concertina along. And we went up to my room, and there was a dinner party, it was a party, you know about twenty, thirty people. And we went up and sequestered ourselves and worked out, I'll never forget the songs, "Blue Skies," and "Old Man River." And we came down and gave them a little musicale. And my father, who was half in the bag, the cigar probably almost fell out of his mouth. And my mother was beaming with pride, "That's my boy, you see, he taught himself all this himself."

MR: And singing too?

MG: No, no. Not at that time.

MR: Just instrumental.

MG: Just instrumental, yeah. And from then on I could do no wrong. "Oh it's wonderful. You should get a better instrument, da, da, da, da." And they were all behind it until of course that moment when you pass beyond it's for fun and it's for high school or school and stuff, and you become very serious about it. And in middle class families, what was middle class then, now the whole definition is topsy turvy it seems, but that, and my mother of course being German had this German accent, and that's when she said, you know, one day she said you know, "Ju mean ju vant to sit in vront of sose svink bands and go chink, chink, chink?" I said, "Yeah, Ma."

MR: You got it.

MG: That's it. I thought immediately that these things always seem to happen with the onset of puberty. And they're very much glandular in nature. And the, you know I saw myself, like the bands I went to see at the Paramount and the Strand and the Capitol Theaters in Manhattan, I saw myself — well, a mustache would be good, hair, there's a lot of goo on the hair, slicked, you know, shiny, wearing one of those mess jackets.

MR: What's a mess jacket?

MG: A mess jacket is a jacket, you know, like the British officers wear, like formal wear, they wore them with striped tuxedo pants, and then the jacket was usually white. It was a summer jacket, and it only came down to here. And then you wore your miniature medals

to play in one of the bands, wow, you know. And I mean that was a great, great ambition in those days.

MR: Almost like today, when a kid thinks of being in a heavy duty, you know, famous rock & roll band. Is that a fair statement? That this was—

MG: Yes. Except there was a difference I think. We knew, it didn't take long before you knew that a lot of hard work was ahead of you before you even could knock on the door, I think. Because although we fantasized and posed in front of the mirror with our instruments, guys with their clarinets and trumpets and everything like that, when you actually went to see one of these bands, you had some youthful arrogance, well I'll get there, but it soon became apparent that it wasn't all that easy. You know first of all in those days, all — not all bands — but most of the bands read. You had to read. And most of the dance orchestrations, I mean that's what most music was for, starting off with high school dances, and then you know into theaters and stuff, and all these guys had their nose in the paper. And the first time I remember looking at one of those stock arrangements of "Stomping at the Savoy," I thought well this is, you know, hieroglyphics. You need the rosetta stone to decipher this. What in the hell is a D flat ninth? What is that? And what is a G flat minor sixth? And all that stuff.

MR: They had the slashes and the chords?

MG: Yeah, yeah. The guitar parts were mostly rhythm parts in those days you know.

MR: Up until that time you had been teaching yourself?

MG: Yes. I never did have a teacher except for some guys, musicians, who'd show me things, you know.

MR: But when you were playing along with a record or something, and you would go and you'd find the right chord, did you have a name for it?

MG: Yeah, I got a book. And it had the little dots and the boxes on it. And pretty soon I got to be, you know and then I would always hang out with piano players, because the piano players were the theoreticians in the band. They'd all, all the guys I mean who played the piano usually had three or four years of music behind them. They could read. They could teach you the song. They would say, "Listen, when you get there play an A minor seven flat five." I'd say, "Well what's that?" "Well it's like a C minor sixth but the A— don't worry about it, I'll play the A in the bass." You know, that kind of thing. And they would sort of bring you up and start saying, "No, no, no, no, that's not right. Play this one, or play that one, or try this here." I remember the first time a friend of mine showed me some hip changes to "Peg O' My Heart." Oh, I was really, I couldn't get enough of the song. "Let's play 'Peg O' My Heart.' Let's play it again."

MR: Yeah, I've got this cool thing here. Yeah it's a whole new tune when you start

MG: Yeah. You start putting in diminished chords in the middle and all kinds of stuff, you know, re-harmonizing it and so forth. And so I'm actually a product of a guy who heard records, and heard some bands, saw some bands, and wanted to play. As opposed to the other kind of guy who, like the piano players, who had started playing, or violin, kids who'd play on violin, they'd play violin for two or three years and stuff, and all of a sudden they discover jazz. Or somebody says "you know you can make some money playing jazz." I was one of those kids, who at about twelve years of age, wanted to play jazz. I remember my first jazz record I ever bought for myself was a Commodore Record called "Paging the Devil" and I think "Way Down Yonder in New Orleans" was on the other side if I'm not mistaken, by Lester Young, Buck Clayton, and the Kansas City Six I think it was. Eddie Durham.

MR: Was Basie on that?

MG: No. That was without Basie. With Eddie Durham on electric guitar, Freddie Green, Walter Page, Jo Jones, the Basie rhythm section without Basie. Contractual reasons obviously. And then Buck Clayton and Lester Young. And the only reason, I didn't know any of these guys, the only reason I bought the record was because of the title, you know I hadn't heard it and I said, "Paging the Devil," wow, that sounds real evil and funky and stuff. And it turned out it was because Walter Page playing the blues and he had a band called the Blue Devils. So that's how that all, as you well know, doing your Basie stuff.

MR: Well if that was your first record, then you had a great introduction—

MG: It's not the first record I heard, but that I actually bought for myself.

MR: Well you had a good thing to listen to with Freddie Green.

MG: You know I went to see bands. I listened to everything. Phil Spitalny and his All-Girl Orchestra, Charlie Spivak, Glen Grey and the Casa Loma Orchestra, Duke Ellington, Bobby Sherwood, a wonderful guitar player that nobody knows about that he was a fine guitar player, sort of buried in the studios. But on this occasion he played some very good guitar but basically he was a trumpet player with the band. That was it, he double played all the instruments. Anything. I'd go to see anything just to see how they did it. I didn't care. Of course, Ellington's band, because I'd read a little bit and heard a little bit, I'd heard some old records, that was a particular thrill and they were certainly wonderful you know. And Benny Goodman I remember with Mike Bryan on guitar and Slam Stewart. But I would go see anything, just to see how the guys did it. When did they plan, when didn't they play, why did they do this, why did they do that? You know that kind of thing. Just to see how they all sat, what kind of guitars they were playing, you know.

MR: And what years was this?

MG: This was during the war. 1944, '45, and '46 right after that.

MR: So the idea of amplification for the guitar, I know Freddie Green was never really amplified right? He just kind of would basically feel that sound.

MG: Not that I know of. He once went out and they got him a mic and an amp or something, but it was never used, and later on I heard that you know when Bobby Hackett played with Glenn Miller, Glenn Miller had him, Bobby didn't have to carry it, the band boy had to carry an amp all over the place, but Bobby never used it, he didn't like it. And no, of course we heard Oscar Moore, that was a hot ticket then, the King Cole Trio was the hot ticket, and we all had those, you know all the kids had those records and we'd listen to them, and of course we knew about the Benny Goodman Sextet with Charlie Christian, all the guys had that, and they were on Columbia I think, yeah. I can remember the labels, you know and stuff. But somehow that never got to me. It's like I loved Django Reinhardt. For one part of my youth I had every Django Reinhardt I could get my hands on. But I never, for some reason, it never occurred to me that I wanted to do that. And I later on, funny, I had so many friends who were really into Django. One guy in Cleveland he said, "I used to tie my fingers, put rubber bands around my fingers to try to ape Django's two fingers" you know that two finger typing technique that he played with. And I mean guys, I know several that were Django freaks, they can play everything by Django. They lived Django, they think Django, and of course later on I found in Paris, in Europe, there are hundreds of them that do Django, with varying degrees of success. But for some reason, I don't think I ever felt, first of all, for some damn reason that I can't understand, I wanted to be a rhythm guitar player at first. And in fact, managed to be just that. And set as my idols, those guys like Allan Reuss, and Mike Bryan and Eddie Condon and Freddie Green and whoever else I could think of. All those guys, and trumpet players and horn players would tell me, "Those are the guys" they would say, "those are the guys. They don't show off, they don't need to take choruses and stuff, but they play for the band. That's a team thing." And of course in a sense they were absolutely right. Because there is a symbiosis that happens between rhythm players, when they get tight and when it really starts to work, that you can't get as a soloist really, at least I've never been able to. It doesn't feel quite the same. It's a special feeling. And a friend of mine called me up just three days, four days ago, he's an amateur guitarist and a collector in Texas. and he called me up and he said, he'd been playing electric guitar all his life and he said he had a teacher, and in Texas he signed up for a course. They have a 23-piece big band, and you sign up for a course. You pay money and you work in the big band. They do Basie and Glenn Miller and stuff like that. And he said "I really had to play rhythm guitar. And my teacher said, 'You know, it will hurt for a while, but you'll get to the next plateau and you'll play, even though it hurts you'll play, and then all of a

jogging or lifting weights or something like similar to that, you know, you have to use a higher action and heavier gauge strings. But once you get it going, you know, he said, "It's a wonderful feeling. I was with the bass and the drums and we were all tight, together and we got a blend" and stuff like that. So but getting back to your question, so that's what I really wanted to do. And it was, if I did take some crappy solos once in a while, that came later. That came because as the music business got worse and worse, I mean less and less employment and groups got smaller and smaller, they wanted somebody who could do something. Hence, I also started to do the vocals. I remember I was in Chicago about 1954, '55 or something like that. Some guys, we were always sitting around the back room during the intermissions you know, and I'd be singing little songs and playing. He says, "Do that on stage." He says, "We need all the help we can get." And I said, oh, you know, I was like totally inhibited about it. So I got up and sort of mumbled and didn't look at the audience and everything, the way you do, but it's like public speaking or something. Gradually they shove you out there enough times and you know you get used to it. That's how that came about. But basically my favorite thing still is to just play in the rhythm section. If they don't give me a solo all night I don't give a damn. You know I don't really care.

MR: That feeling that a good rhythm section with a piano, guitar and bass and drums, it's hard to define when it's really happening. But as you said, it's a special feeling.

MG: Well I'm writing a book, believe it or not, a monograph on rhythm guitar, the history of. Somebody asked me to do it and by the time I get finished with it I'll have made a penny a page or something. Because it's a labor of love. And in it I try to describe, first of all, to tackle those problems, the questions, the terms that nobody can really define. What is swing? You know, and I describe it, it's more one of those qualities, it's like if you ask somebody what is the feeling of well being? Well, nobody can really, it's really very hard to define. You notice it first most I suppose by its absence. When things are wrong, when you feel sickly or ill, you know, but you don't usually get up in the morning and say, "Gosh, I feel great today, I have a feeling of well being." You know, the same thing here. Good playing with good time, articulating the time properly, and eventually getting into swinging, is something that you know, you don't usually say, "Gee we're playing with good time. Gosh, we're really swinging." It should just come naturally. And I usually tell the musicians, you know and I say to them, I often say to them, "Don't swing, don't cook, don't sauté, don't do anything, don't braise, nothing." I say, "Just play the song. Play the song with a good tone, the right changes, a nice beat, and if it's gonna happen." It's like making love you know, you can't bang the door down and seize the girl and throw her on the bed, "This is it." You've got to have a little din din, you've got have a

have a little chance to get acquainted. It's like that. And the same thing with music. Sometimes these jazz guys, you know they come loaded, like, "We're gonna swing, we're gonna cook tonight." [scats] I mean where is there, what's going to happen, it's rather unnatural to me.

MR: Yeah, and where is it going to go from there?

MG: Natural is, you know [scats] just play. If it's gonna get there, it'll get there. If it isn't, all the histrionics and all the effort and all the straining isn't going to make it happen. And I've seen that happen so many times. Guys are straining. They're going to tell their story. But it doesn't work. And what that magic ingredient is, what that compatibility is that brings this out, is hard to say. And I mean I don't think anybody's ever gotten to a definition, and probably they shouldn't.

MR: When we're talking definitions, when I look at your CDs and the kind of music you do, is there a way you can describe "trad jazz" and "hot?" When you use the word "hot" you know was hot, did that mean jazz too?

MG: Yes. Hot jazz, as opposed to cool jazz. I think it's just a physical thing. I mean certain people like to live in Spain, certain people like to live in Vermont. I mean people make a lot of this. There is room for all of them. I happen to have been weaned, early on, not only on Louis Armstrong and Bix Beiderbecke and Bessie Smith and Duke Ellington, of course. When I was just thirteen and fourteen it was wonderful in New York particularly because we had disc jockeys, jazz disc jockeys, who didn't, who were very catholic in their tastes. I use the word not in the religious sense, the other sense. I mean you'd hear Erroll Garner's first recording, "White Rose Bounce" or one of those things, and the next tune would be Jack Bland and his Rhythm Makers, and the next tune would be Duke Ellington's "Main Stem," and the next tune might be Bessie Smith. So you had this whole mish mosh. And I never — and a Benny Goodman sextet thing followed by Lester Young with Johnny Guanieri and Slam Stewart and Sid Catlett followed by Bix Beiderbecke and his gang, I mean it was like that. And so it was only later on that that separation came. That came during the bebop era, through the efforts of guys like Leonard Feather and stuff, to somehow, you know, call the old stuff is crappy. And frankly, I don't know if I'm answering your question, but I find the notion of progress in music spurious. There is change of course, but whether you can say that Alban Berg is per se better than Johann Bach, you know, than Bach, I mean it's different. It came later. It's got a thing of this, and this, and this is the way I feel about it. But at that time there was somehow this division between squares and moldy figs, and boppers, and those who were hip you know and it was a terrible thing. All of a sudden, guys who, life is short, and in twenty years had gotten their art to a form of perfection, guys like Bud Freeman or

You know they're forty years old and they're passé. Ridiculous. Ridiculous. What do they want from a guy? That he change his colors every five years which way the wind blows, all of a sudden you become a Stan Kenton, you change from— So anyway—

MR: Was it mostly the non-musicians that started that? Was it the writers and the critics?

MG: Many musicians felt, younger ones, yeah I think they had a lot to do with it. They fanned the flames. They saw good copy. Divide and— bebop versus— they even use to have those concerts at Birdland. The moldy figs. Here's Max Kaminsky and Edmond Hall and who else and whatever. And over here are Diz and Bird or whatever it is. You know, and this is going to get people to come in. It's sort of like that trumped up, like the boxing thing, you know when they all, "I can knock 'em flat" and all that stuff. You know, hokey kind of stuff. But no, I liked, when I say "hot music" hot music to me was, I was especially fond for some reason that I can't define, I would just latch on to certain things. I especially was fond of the Chicago guys. Joe Sullivan, Teschemacker, Bud, those guys, that whole school. Dave Tough, Wettling, all those guys. I was very fond of them. And they were like the fobbs. Later on it occurred to me they were the first really middle class, high school kids type guys who really embraced jazz as a group. They and Bix and a few others. Otherwise jazz sort of came, if you pardon the expression, it was sort of considered as coming from the wrong side of the tracks you know. But that's not why. And I always loved of course, I always loved Fats, who I considered a hot player. These were hot players, you know. Herman Autrey, who I rarely got a chance to play with, and guys like that. But I always felt that my allegiance, just my physical type, the way, something—I like hot music. I'm not necessarily, that doesn't mean you hate the other stuff, but it's just not what really grabs you. It's not the path you would choose to follow.

MR: Now you, from telling me your schedule, are quite a globe trotter. I mean this music has gotten you around to some different places. What is the European thing for this music?

MG: Listen, if I could have done, when I was twenty-five, twenty-six, seven years old and I was working in a saloon in Chicago, six nights a week for five years and I said I'm buried, I'm forgotten, they'll never know who I am, help, help, I'm drowning. And I would have gladly given a toe or allowed myself to be horsewhipped to go on the road, you know, to go places. To go to England. To go to Japan. To go here, to go there. And the opportunity didn't really occur until I got to New York in '75, back to New York, and then three months later I'm with Dick Hyman doing a tour you know, and stuff like that. And the point is that in America jazz is dying on the vine largely, I mean as far as it being a viable, popular music, it's become an art music. It's not played hardly in saloons anymore. It's not played in dance halls, it's played on stages, concert stages. And the thing about Europe is, England has a lot of places where they like jazz. And Germany and

again next May. And Scandinavia and stuff like that. And they seem to think it's a big deal. They have work. They use it, as I was telling you, they use it sort of, which is okay, they use it as accompaniment to store features. And in Germany they have these department stores that they are allowed to take a certain deduction, amount of their taxes, in fact they're supposed to, to support the arts. It would be a great thing in this country but, try to get old Jesse and those guys convinced of it. Fat chance. And so sometimes they take it and the townships in Germany, this may be changing of course as the economics change, have like cultural programs that are subsidized. Like at the village theater there'll be like one week there'll be a ballet troupe, the next week a poetry reading, the next week a jazz group, the next week a string quartet. That kind of thing. But it's subsidized. So that's, when people book you over there for a tour, they often take advantage of that. And I went over there once with, we did some of those with Yank Lawson and Haggart and those guys and did a bunch of those. And they treated us well. Young people came. It was like a cultural event, not just a jazz event where they say well, you know, they're playing that old stuff, we don't, it ain't rock so we're not interested. Like this is culture. It was just like next week they're doing Ibsen and this week they're having American jazz musicians, and it's good for you, sort of thing. And the department stores subsidize tours. I know guys, I've done it myself, go over and they finance the gigs by a band. You play for like a two hour concert after working hours sort of, or Thursday nights or something when they're open late. Right in the middle of the store. Banks subsidize that and stuff. You know it's sort of like good will and cultural. It's like when I do in Princeton once in a while, they have Palmer Square in the middle of Princeton, they have like in the fall always a day where they, couple of days, a weekend where they have stuff. You know, "Come down, shop downtown and see what we got." You know, this will get them downtown and they'll buy something, and they'll think it is, which it is, much nicer than the miracle mile outside of town with the WalMart.

MR: Who—when you are able to play with different people overseas, who are some of your favorite musicians to play with? Is that, that's probably a big question? Are there certain individuals?

MG: You mean foreign musicians?

MR: No, well like guys from here, but like you mentioned Dick Hyman—

MG: Yeah, I was just over there and played some with Ralph Sutton, he's a fine player. I also did some things with the Summit Reunion, you know I played with them twenty years ago, Davern and Wilber. They're fun to play with, did the Bern Jazz Festival, did five concerts, they're good to play with. I mean a lot of guys are good to play with. I mean if I went through the catalogue, usually of course I try to bring the guys I work with. Like I

York has a couple, two or three unplugged bass players. I mean really unplugged. They really play acoustic bass with gut strings. And it's like fifty years ago. It's wonderful because the souped up bass and acoustic guitar never really quite hit it off like totally acoustic. There's also a factor of resistance in the guitar, when you have to work at it, and do this. You know when it's amplified you have a little tiny pick and you have a light action, the strings lie close to the fingerboard, you don't have to work, and you sort of go [scats]. And it's sort of confidential. But when you really have to slug the damn thing, it gives it a percussive dimension that the other one doesn't hand. And same thing with bass. I used to watch, it must have been Milt Hinton—I remember Slam Stewart with Benny Goodman and I remember the Calloway band around those years, '44, '45, so it must have been Milt and I remember it seemed to me that by the second number, you know they didn't have any amps in those days, and by the second tune, the band jacket was already getting sweated through. But you felt that energy, that [scats] that you can't quite get through an amp. Different.

MR: They must have had some endurance.

MG: Well yeah.

MR: You must have a lot of endurance too.

MG: Well you sacrifice something for it. Not that I ever had it. Some of this, you know we compensate for our shortcomings. And maybe rhythm guitar is an easy thing, it can't be heard too well. And maybe when I was just a kid trying to get it together, it was a good instrument to be part of the group with, without ever really having to be put on the spot. That could be a thing too. I've thought about that as I review my life. I've thought about that.

MR: Why did I pick this exact thing to do?

MG: And then it's also like piano in the sense that your hands are always onto something. You know the saxophone players when they're not playing they have to stand there and either look engaged or sometimes they look disengaged. Or the trumpet players or others. But the rhythm section's always got something under the hands. And I remember when I was a kid I used to have poison ivy a lot and stuff like that I'd be going like this. And my mother would say, "Don't scratch, you'll spread it." And there's nothing like a guitar or a piano, because it's like scratching. You're doing this. Something's always happening. You're always busy. You're never bored. I always pitied the poor guys that have these long rests and they sit there while some guy's taking a solo, you know.

MR: Yeah. A lot of down time.

MG: Yeah. But on the other hand, there can be miles and miles and miles of B flat. I remember doing a thing once in Nice and they did, it was Harry Edison and, oh I can't remember

And I remember it was, they were doing a Basie set. It was supposed to be an hour long, or an hour and fifteen minutes like here. And they did two tunes. What was one of them?

MR: Probably one of them was a blues, right.

MG: Probably. Or "Jumpin' at the Woodside" or something. And man, you know, after the first twenty-five minutes, you don't know what to do anymore. You know [scats] the bass players are going down, they're going up, they're going sideways. You know, how much can you do with a B flat chord? I mean you can bow you know, you can play, but they're supposed to be playing just four notes.

MR: But that whole thing with the jam sessions, the horn players, they can line up and say that— I always felt sorry for you guys in the rhythm section, because you just, you had to keep going for everybody.

MG: You know, but that's the other, that's the down side of the picture. While these guys are on the ego trips, you're, you know, one more. You're back there going [scats] for yards and yards and yards. But maybe it's a different kind of thing. Like you get a satisfaction from doing like shingling, you know, like if you get into it. You keep nailing those shingles up, after a while it gets to be kind of a pattern, the rhythm of your life.

MR: That's a pretty good analogy. Let me just, before we wrap up, ask, where do you find these tunes?

MG: I get guys to send me tapes. And I buy those things downstairs. Like downstairs they have those collections — Ethel Waters, Bob Howard, Teddy Wilson—I'm just trying to think. You know those, I've heard all, not all, but a lot of the greats, the things you hear over and over again. You know the great ones. And then you go looking for oddball stuff to play. And guys make up tapes of oddball things. Cassettes of strange things. I have friends who send me stuff. Wonderful. Tunes I never heard in my life by groups I never heard. You know and I mix it up. And you get ideas from that. Yeah. It's interesting. There's a world, a wealth of material out there. It hasn't been plumbed. And the guys at these — that's the problem of course, we don't play together ever enough. You used to play in a joint, you'd play five or six nights a week with the same guys. Man, you could play three months, four months with the same guys, and then come to one of these festivals. You'd steamroller 'em. I mean everybody comes to these festivals, they're always saying, "Um, what do you want to play, um." "Well I don't know that one too well, do you know this one?" "Well, how does the bridge go, oh, yeah." And finally they always wind up playing "Undecided" or a riff on "I Got Rhythm" or you know, often the same kind of thing, and it would really be nice to have some group and do some of these things. That's where the vocals come in. Most of those songs, a lot of those songs don't mean a hell of a lot without vocals. To John Q. Public out there it's a tune. But what does

example that Ivy Anderson sang with Ellington and Wingy Manone sang it on records, is "Isn't Love the Strangest Thing." You know, pretty melody, everything like that, but I dare say it wouldn't mean much if you didn't have a vocal to sing with it. And they say, "Oh gee, what a nice thought," you know, "how romantic."

MR: Well even some of our best horn players that we've talked to have mentioned they know the words when they play some of those songs. You need to know the words whether they're being sung or not.

MG: You need to know, if you're distorting it, I feel it's nice to know you're doing violence to it. It's nice to know that you're painting a mustache on Mona Lisa when it's happening, you know what I mean? Because you can, one of the things that's often fun that Jimmy Lunceford and Red Nichols used to do was take fast tunes and play them slow, and slow tunes and play them fast. And you know before Trummy Young came on to the scene, I think everybody played [scats]. You know it was one of those kinds of tunes. And then he made kind of [scats] a bouncy thing out of it. And that's fun, if the tune lends itself to that. So yeah, I think those songs, there's a wealth of tin pan alley stuff. Piles and piles of it. Undiscovered. Lying in wait.

MR: For our younger viewers, can you tell us what tin pan alley means?

MG: Oh, tin pan alley was basically, at first, there are books on it, first it was someplace else, but it wound up being the Brill Building on Broadway in midtown Manhattan, where guys— hi young viewers. Tin Pan Alley was where guys named Sid and Morty worked on out-of-tune pianos in little cubicles, smoked foul cigars, breathed on each other the foul cigars and tried to just get on top of the latest trend. When they had all these songs about, you know, if you don't like ham that melts in your mouth, if you don't like da, da, da, da, stay out of the south, and if you don't— and they had that whole thing about that people called him Loving Sam, the sheik of Alabam, there's a whole thing, everything, all the songs were about this— and as George S. Kaufmann once said about the twenties, he said, it was an era when all the Broadway sports got on the midnight choo choo for Alabama at Penn Station and got off in Newark. They'd never been south of Coney Island, these guys. Then when they wrote about Hawaii, on the beach at Waikiki and all this stuff, they had a couple of postcards, you know, that's all. And during the war, you know, Rose O'Day and Johnny Doughboy [sings] found a rose in Ireland and all that stuff. These guys are still sitting up there pounding it out on their thing with the racing sheet in their back pocket.

MR: That's fascinating because later on the Brill Building became the home of some of the rock & roll writers too.

MG: Oh, really?

MR: Yeah, Carole King, Neil Sedaka, they worked there. Probably the same room, it probably still smelled like cigar smoke.

MG: Yeah. Only difference is now it's pot.

MR: Change the music a little bit.

MG: Yeah. I've got an old-time guitar player friend who called me up not long ago, and his son is playing lead guitar for Rod Stewart in Europe for a year, and he makes, this guy I suppose in his career if he made three or four hundred dollars a week it was a good week. His son makes five thousand dollars a week, plus a hundred and forty dollars a day for food you know and stuff, and he told me, he described the column speakers they had and everything. And he said that the over-thirty guys who go to listen to this music, the audiences, if they don't feel a sort of sound system that actually gives them a kind of constriction of the chest, then they want their money back. And he says the guys in the band, there's no monitors anymore, they all use, I didn't know this, they all use earphones because they're all getting deaf, hearing loss — and I'm wondering to myself, I mean that's about as far removed from anything that I've ever gotten into. The closest I get are these deaf soundmen you have to work with. You know these cretins. Can you imagine Carnegie Hall? They've got a sound man, now this was twenty years ago, George Wein was doing a bunch of concerts and I was standing, waiting in the back and there was a sound man and he's got one of these work shirts on, and it says on the back "Carnegie Hall" and on the front it says his name, you know "Al" and he's pushing, he's working the sound board. And they're doing a band up there, and the guy is playing an alto sax solo, and he's pushing the gain on the trombone. And I said, "You know that's an alto sax that's playing, not a trombone." "Oh, yeah, oh yeah, thanks a lot, there." I mean the artists' work is in the hands of these cretins, or creetins, depends whether you're in England, in England they call them creetins. I mean this is like getting the Boston Symphony to record on one of those things you used to have in those booths you'd go in, you know, and send a message home to mom [holds nose] "Hi Mom."

MR: I know. I think the sound people have to justify themselves, so they've got to push things you know. And even here sometimes, I sometimes feel like, I mean sometimes things have to be amplified, if you're playing a huge place. But sometimes I wonder, couldn't you hang a big mic over the band and pick up the band?

MG: And leave it off.

MR: And leave it off.

MG: Yeah. Fake mikes. We played last year I think it was, we played in the Executive Suites across the road. They were putting people up for cheap or something, so the guy here made a deal with them and stuff, and so we had to do like two or three hour thing, over

no piano, it had never had any music. It was just some place where they piped in this stuff, and the big T.V. screens so they could watch the testosterones playing the spiroketes you know, in football or something. And so that was off, and so there we were and they'd forgotten to put a sound system in. It was absolutely acoustic. It was like 1930 when you played a job at a dance hall. There wasn't anything. Zilch. You had to have a megaphone to sing. And so we played, and they shut up, and it was probably the best job venue we ever played here, anyplace maybe, I don't know. Because they were absolutely raptly obedient, quiet, and they understood what was happening and they heard the instruments. Guys who'd spent quite a bit of time and effort trying to develop good tones and good projection and stuff, and they really heard them working it, and liking it. And every time Kenny Davern for example is a great non-mic man. He gets, "turn 'em all off." And the sound man is taking hemlock back there. And, "Turn 'em all off" and he plays absolutely acoustic, and the audience usually loves it. Especially in these concert halls. They were built for Caruso. They were built even for a lieder singer, standing in the crook of the piano.

MR: Well I'm going to assume that you're probably not going to be joining Rod Stewart within anytime soon, but—

MG: Heaven forbid.

MR: We have really enjoyed talking with you today. And on behalf of Hamilton College I'd like to thank Marty Grosz for joining us. You have a unique perspective on, in fact, it's reflected in what you do. You know you're one of the few guys who plays acoustically.

MG: No I don't look upon it as anything else, if I can just do one thing, I look upon it as an entertainment. And I wish to make one closing statement, I wish that people would dance to the music again. The best jobs I ever had in my life were dance gigs. And I don't mean that because it's a lost thing and nobody's doing it anymore and so I hark back to it, but I mean they were really fun because you could really play unselfconsciously. Just as long as they didn't pay any attention to you, you served a purpose, you got them on the floor, and got them milling about and everything like that and jumping to the music, and that was when I heard piano players and stuff play so freely and so strangely, and so inspiredly, because they didn't have to rely upon, you know, hitting home runs, which you know jazz has become concert stage music. And guys hit home runs. They play high notes, they do drum solos that go on forever and ever and ever, and these sure-fire devices just like concert artists do with their cadenzas and their bravura performances and stuff. And that didn't used to be. You used to play in little joints and saloons or in little dance places and just play unselfconsciously. And that was the most fun of all. And if you could have a few laughs doing, entertain a little bit, great. And if the music happened

just to hear the melody and have a good beat. And then if it got going, and if somebody really started improvising, but it was done without a thought to I gotta get 'em—I gotta kill 'em. You know, this guy took three choruses, I got to take four choruses 'cause I gotta top him. It wasn't that kind of feel. You know just keep the thing going and play something interesting.

MR: Some good thoughts. And I'm going to have to go listen to you tonight and see if that happens.

MG: Well that whole thing will come crashing apart. It will be like the Hindenberg.

MR: I don't know, I see, maybe the next CD, maybe there's a title there for you, "The Hindenberg" or something. But I'm not sure, is this your latest?

MG: No.

MR: Okay.

MG: I've done several since then. I turn them out like kielbasas you know, I mean, because in England and Germany they want something new. "Anything new?" "Anything?" "Oh, gosh, we got that one."

MR: But "Songs I Learned at my Mother's Knee and Other Low Joints" is the title that we started off with, and your mother's comment, which is really memorable. So thanks again for your time.

MG: Thank you.